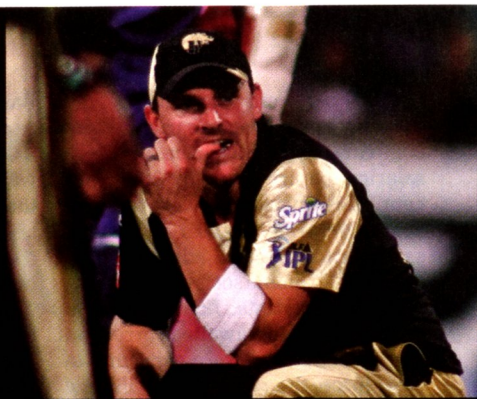


How and why the wheels came off the IPL's glamour team, leaving SRK's men dazed, disoriented and totally confused



KNIGHTMARE



(CLOCKWISE FROM ABOVE LEFT)
MCCULLUM, BUCHANAN,
GANGULY, ISHANT
SHARMA AND SHAH
RUKH KHAN

| By Sharda Ugra |

See, we're probably getting this all wrong. The Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) are not really supposed to be a cricket team. It is the IPL's version of Cartoon Network, sorry Kartoon Network. Either that or its drama company which would explain the Julius Caesar storyline and facial expressions out of Hamlet. Clearly, there are more things in batting and bowling, Buck, than are dreamt of in your philosophy.

Now, never mind the professorial air of chief coach John 'Buck' Buchanan, KKR was supposed to be the showbiz team of the IPL. They were the boys with bling, the guys with glamour and the coolest uniform in all the League. They got showered with cool

gifts because they were Shah Rukh Khan's stud-muffins, not this dysfunctional collective of Devdas clones.

Three weeks into IPL Season 2 and the only way KKR can make the semi-finals is if they win all their last five matches and everything else gets rained off. That is not a script Bollywood could entertain, not even with Six-Pack Khan as the leading man, and he, at the moment, is getting no breaks either.

Nor any cash. Shah Rukh is trying to sell 20 per cent of his stake in the team, valued at Rs 300 crore, and must do so quickly before the valuation drops. He denies the sale itself saying, "Even if I want to sell KKR, nobody in this world has enough to pay for it. Because nobody can invest so much love in KKR as I have done and will do."

Love or no love, the traumatised

superstar fled South Africa, after the team lost their fifth match, promising to return only when they won again.

Like everything else KKR have tried, that too didn't work. The team has won only one in their first nine matches. The captain's batting and manner now resembles an imploding firework, the team line-up is more scrambled than eggs, the fielders have doughnuts for hands. Even Shane Warne expressed his concern over the travails of the men in black.

But for KKR, events in South Africa have only been the continuation of their season that now resembles a daily soap in which every episode ends in a melodramatic flourish. In an elaborate but horribly botched plan to give their 'icon' player and captain, Sourav Ganguly, the heave-ho off centre stage, Buchanan talked about four